



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

LN905 Social Media – Topic Input

Issues - brainstorming

What are the main issues/hot topics related to the topic of social media? E.g. *privacy*



Discussion Questions:

1. What are the most popular social media platforms in your home country?
2. Has social media influenced communication styles in your country or culture?
3. How do you personally use social media in your academic or professional life?
4. In what ways has social media influenced your field of study or future career?
5. Do you think concerns about data privacy, misinformation, and online behaviour vary globally? Should there be universal regulations for social media platforms?
6. Should universities or employers monitor students' or employees' social media activity?
7. Overall, do you think social media contributes more to global understanding or to misinformation and division? Why?
8. What are the psychological effects of social media, and how can individuals maintain a healthy relationship with these platforms while staying connected?
9. What are the biggest challenges or risks associated with social media use today?
10. How do you envision the evolution of social media in the next decade?

Definitions

Definitions are important in social science. For example, the statement “privacy is important” can have different interpretations and applications depending on how people define privacy.

Definition of Privacy	Interpretation of “Privacy is important”	Social Media Concern
Control over personal information	Users should choose what to share and with whom	Privacy settings, audience selection
Anonymity	Users should be unidentifiable or untraceable online	Desire for pseudonyms, no real-name policies, anonymous postings
Protection from surveillance	Users should be free from tracking by companies or governments	Data collection, targeted ads, surveillance
The right to be left alone	Users should be able to avoid harassment or unwanted attention	Comment moderation, private profiles

Definitions

A definition should indicate:

- the general form/type of entity/phenomenon being identified
- its main use/function
- its purpose
- its typical context
- its main features



Example:

Privacy is a concept (FORM) that concerns the control individuals or groups have over access to their personal information and activities (FUNCTION) in order to protect autonomy, dignity, and freedom from unwanted intrusion (PURPOSE) within social, legal, and technological environments (CONTEXT); it involves principles such as consent, confidentiality, and data protection, and is shaped by cultural norms, legal frameworks, and digital technologies (FEATURES).

In pairs/threes, work together to write a similar definition for social media.

Social media is...



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Impact of Social Media on Youth

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=soHn6t_jjIw

Watch the short talk above and note down the main points the speaker makes:

Compare with a partner or in a group of three and see if you have noted down the same points.

In light of the points made in the video, look at one of the set of issues on the next page and discuss to what extent you feel they are a significant for you and your peers. What solutions, if any, do you think there might be to these problems?

Group A	Group B
1. Spending too much time on social media 2. Getting addicted to social media 3. The update syndrome 4. Neglecting family and responsibilities 5. Dependence on online friends	1. Managing social media time 2. <u>W</u>asting time on social media 3. Reducing attention span 4. <u>L</u>ack of focus and productivity 5. The FOMO (Fear of Missing Out) Syndrome
Group C	Group D
1. <u>W</u>asting time playing games 2. <u>S</u>eeking validation 3. <u>R</u>elationship issues due to social media 4. Infidelity on social media 5. <u>D</u>isturbing privacy issues	1. <u>F</u>alling for fake identities 2. <u>G</u>etting duped on social media 3. <u>H</u>ealth issues due to social media 4. <u>N</u>egative impact on academics 5. <u>D</u>angers of cybercrime and bullying

Extra Task:

If you have time, read this LSE blog written by a student. Does she raise any of the same issues above?

<https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/psychologylse/2022/03/31/scroll-like-click-post-analysing-how-social-media-has-rewired-our-brains-and-reprogrammed-behaviour/>